

Κριτίας ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Critias of Athens Between Verse and the Thirty Tyrants

eul_aid: bzo

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Συναγωγή](#) [Collection](#)
Affiliation: [Sophist](#)

Critias was an Athenian aristocrat, poet, and thinker of the fifth century BCE. He is most infamously remembered as the leading and most violent member of the Thirty Tyrants, the brutal oligarchic regime that ruled Athens after its defeat in the Peloponnesian War. Critias was killed in 403 BCE when democratic forces overthrew the Thirty.

In his youth, he was associated with the philosopher Socrates and was a student of the sophist Gorgias. His literary works survive only in fragments, including tragedies, elegies, prose works on constitutions, and political speeches. One fragment, from a satyr play called **Sisyphus**, is particularly significant. In it, a character argues that the gods were a clever invention by a shrewd man to frighten people into good behavior, even in secret. This fragment is considered a key document for understanding radical sophistic theories about religion, law, and society.

Critias remains a controversial figure. His political life made him an archetype of the cruel tyrant in Athenian history. Philosophically, he is grouped with the sophists, and his surviving writings provide insight into the oligarchic admiration for Spartan discipline and the critical examination of traditional beliefs during his era.

Works (5)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἀνακρέοντος καὶ Κοτάβου](#) · [Fragments on Anacreon and Cotabus](#) · 81 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Heracles in the Underworld](#) · 112 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Inventions and Praises](#) · 7 passages
- [Πειρίθους Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Pirithous, Fragments](#) · 7 passages
- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 23 passages

Other Sophist Authors

- [Ἀχιλλεὺς ὁ Τατίος ὁ Ἀλεξανδρεὺς](#) · [Achilles Tatius of Alexandria](#) · 1 work
- [Κλαύδιος Αἰλιανός](#) · [Aelian of Praeneste](#) · 4 works
- [Πόπλιος Αἴλιος Ἀριστείδης Θεόδωρος](#) · [Aelius Aristides of Smyrna](#) · 3 works
- [Αἴλιος Διονύσιος ὁ Ἀλικαρνασσεύς](#) · [Aelius Dionysius of Halicarnassus](#) · 1 work
- [Αἴλιος Θέων ὁ σοφιστής](#) · [Aelius Theon the Sophist](#) · 1 work
- [Ἀλκιδάμας ὁ Ἐλαεύς](#) · [Alcidamas of Elaea](#) · 1 work

- Ἀλκίφρων ὁ Σοφιστής · Alciphron the Sophist · 1 work
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ τοῦ Νουμήνιου · Alexander Son of Numenius · 2 works
- Ἀλέξανδρος ὁ Ἐφέσιος · Alexander the Ephesian Poet · 1 work
- Ἀμφικράτης Ἀθηναῖος · Amphicrates Atheniensis · 1 work
- Ἀνώνυμος ὑπόμνημα εἰς Ἀφθόνιον · Anonymous Commentary on Aphthonius · 2 works
- Ἀντιφῶν ὁ Ἀθηναῖος · Antiphon of Athens · 9 works